ENVIRONMENTAL DESIGN

The Blue Zones of Happiness

Lessons from the World's Happiest People

Dan Buettner · 2017

The explorer behind the Blue Zones longevity research visits the happiest places on Earth and shows how to redesign your own surroundings so wellbeing becomes the easy default. Foreword by Ed Diener.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- Vivid reporting from Costa Rica, Denmark and Singapore[1,3]
- Practical changes for your home, work, friendships and money[4,6]
- A self-test to find where your happiness is thin[1,4]



GET THE BOOK

The Blue Zones of Happiness by Dan Buettner
National Geographic, 2017. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *The Blue Zones of Happiness* by Dan Buettner. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Shape your surroundings

Buettner's reporting suggests the happiest people don't try harder. They live in places that make good days easy: walkable streets, short commutes, close friends nearby, homes that invite rest. Change your environment, and your behavior follows.[1,4,5]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Social time matters**
   Buettner points to research suggesting the happiest people spend about six hours a day with others, far more than most people do.[6,8]

2. **The commute is a tax**
   Long commutes drag down happiness. Living close enough to walk to work is ideal.[4,6]

3. **Purpose beats pay**
   In Denmark, a strong safety net frees people to choose work for interest rather than need.[3,5]

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THE FRAMEWORK

The Three Strands of Happiness[1,3]

Buettner braids happiness from three strands, and finds a country that excels at each.[1,3]

1 Pleasure

Enjoying your days · Costa Rica

Day-to-day positive emotion. Costa Ricans enjoy strong family and faith ties and lots of daily socializing.[3,4]

Try: Build more small, shared rituals into each day.

2 Purpose

Meaning and engagement · Denmark

Meaningful activity that uses your strengths, supported by trust, clubs and volunteering.[3,4,5]

Try: Join a club or volunteer.[6]

3 Pride

Satisfaction with life · Singapore

How you rate your life overall. Singapore scores high thanks to security and clear paths to success.[3,4]

Try: Live within your means and set reachable goals.[7]

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

The Happiness Test

The book's self-test for finding your weakest strand.[1,4]

1. Take the test, or rate pleasure, purpose and pride from 1 to 10.
2. Find your weakest strand.
3. Read the chapter for the area of life most tied to it.

Design your Life Radius

The book's practical chapters, one area of life at a time.[1,2]

1. Community: favour walkability, nature and trust.[4]
2. Workplace and home: shorten the commute; keep the TV out of the main room.[4]
3. Social life: a few close friends, a weekly family meal.[6]
4. Inner life: know your purpose, volunteer, try new things.[9]

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Rate pleasure, purpose and pride from 1 to 10.
2. Log how many hours you spent with people yesterday.
3. Make one change to your surroundings.
4. Start one standing social ritual.

REFLECT

Which strand is thinnest in your life right now?

What in your surroundings makes a good day harder than it needs to be?

Try it in Sedi: Give each strand its own board in Boardly, with one goal on each.

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READ THE BOOK

🌍 The Blue Zones of Happiness

Dan Buettner · National Geographic · 2017

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Dan Buettner or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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